performance of these states in healthcare and education. The top four states in NITI Aayog's Health Index 2019-20 are from the south—Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh—while the bottom four are from the Hindi heartland—UP, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. The affluent south Indian states have done well primarily because of their investment legacy in healthcare and education.

Another sharp differentiator is in nutrition levels. India is home to a quarter of all undernourished people worldwide. In October 2020, a paper by Kalyani Raghunathan of the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI), published a paper in the *Food Policy* journal, showed that 60 per cent of Indians could not afford a nutritious diet, a majority of them in the Hindi heartland and eastern states. In five states—Bihar, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, UP and Chhattisgarh—the figures range from 43-52 per cent, reveals the NITI Aayog's MPI. In Kerala and Tamil Nadu, the share is 15 per cent and 25 per cent respectively.

The indicators in education also reflect the disparity among states. The share of population deprived of schooling in Bihar, Jharkhand, UP and Rajasthan ranges from 27 to 17 per cent (MPI figures). The corresponding percentages for Kerala, Himachal Pradesh, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu are 2-7 per cent.

These differences, when seen in the context of the recent National Family Health Survey (NFHS) 5, also break several social myths. In several states, a political discourse seeking to blame Muslims for high population growth has gained ground. Ironically, the NFHS-5 reveals that the country's fertility rate—children per woman—has fallen to 2, below the replacement level (set at 2.1, the baseline required to balance the number of births and deaths in a country). At that rate, the population neither grows nor declines, and remains stable. Falling below 2.1 means India is not facing a population explosion and is instead looking at a decline in the future. The NFHS-5 has already shown that the share of under-15 population in the country has declined from 28.6 per cent in 2015-16 to 26.5 per cent in 2019-21.

More importantly, Jammu and Kashmir—the state-turned-Union territory and the only region with a Muslim majority population (68 per cent)—recorded the lowest fertility rate at 1.4. Assam, which has the second highest share of Muslim population—34 per cent—showed a fertility rate of 1.9, again below the national average. In contrast, the two states with the highest fertility rates are Bihar (3) and UP (2.4), both of whom bring up the bottom in the MPI indicators related to healthcare and education.

Experts say that higher levels of education and access to healthcare in affluent states—irrespective of religion—resulted in a higher age of marriage for many women, consequently forcing a drop in fertility rates. "Fertility has a significantly high association with education rather than religion or caste," says Prof. Sayeed Unisa, head, department of biostatistics and epidemiology, International Institute for Population Sciences, Mumbai.

While India's 1.3 billion population—often considered the root of many social evils—has stabilised, an uncomfortably large section of citizens remains engulfed in poverty. Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman asserted in her budget speech that the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government seeks to empower the poor and the marginalised by providing access to housing, electricity, cooking gas and water and ensuring financial inclusion. Between 2005-06 and 2015-16, the share of the population that was multidimensionally poor dropped from 54.7 per cent to 27.5 per cent. The challenge for the current government is not to allow the pandemic to reverse that trend. ■

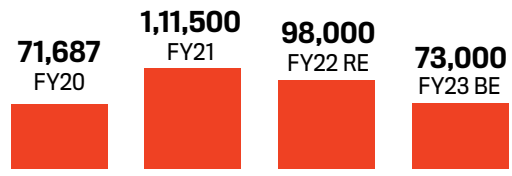
HELPING HANDS

Central government schemes to provide relief to the poor

NAME OF SCHEME	WHAT IS IT?	TOTAL BENEFICIARIES*
Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana	Rs 2 lakh accidental insurance scheme at an annual premium of Rs 12	268,200,000
PM Shram Yogi Maan-Dhan Yojana	Old age pension scheme for unorganised workers	4,594,095
Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana	Rs 2 lakh life insurance scheme at an annual premium of Rs 330	119,000,000
Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)**	Transfer of various cash benefits to bank accounts	₹2.1 lakh crore
Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana	Free LPG connections to women Below Poverty Line	89,864,645
Aayushman Bharat PM Jan Arogya Yojana	Free health insurance cover to 500 million people	26,136,725
PM Awas Yojana	Free housing to poor	22,372,145
PM Jan Dhan Yojana	Zero balance bank account for the poor	N.A.
PM Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana	Income support of Rs 6,000 per year to all farmer families	119,518,991

*Source: PMO Dashboard; *as on 30-1-2022; **DBT shows amount transferred*

MNREGA ALLOCATION HAS RETURNED TO PRE-COVID LEVELS



Figures in Rs crore